ground but still had BPL cards. We studied this deeply and worked to ensure that those who deserved it really get a voice, get toilets, gas connections, health services, get food in their house. This is the work we did and so BJP is the party of the poor.'[2] I examine these claims in detail in Chapter 4. For now, Maurya's assertion is a substantial one to note for a party that was once seen as a purely urban party.

Importantly, the BJP made these rural and rurban gains without losing its urban support base (see Figure 2.4). This is why, when I put the same question to the BJP's other deputy chief minister in UP, Dinesh Sharma, he answered, 'The BJP in real terms is now a party of both the village and the town. It is not only of the village, and not only of the town.'[3] The numbers clearly show two trends: the 'ruralisation of the BJP', and the 'proletarianization' of the party, as the social scientist Diego Maiorana concluded when he analysed post-poll survey data from the National Election Studies, collected by the Centre for Developing Societies in 2019. The BJP performed 'exceptionally well in rural areas', he found. Similarly, the more rural or rurban a constituency, the more likely that the BJP would do better there.[4]

Figure 2.3: The BJP Advances, Powered by Deep Inroads into Rural Areas (2009–2019 Lok Sabha Polls)